

pick of the week



Chennai on beat

Get ready to eat, groove and soak up some Chennai vibes at *The Hindu's* Made Of Chennai Food & Music Festival. With 40-plus food stalls and five-plus hours of live music, the evening features performances by Chinmayi Sripada, Antony Dassan, Paal Dabba, Vihara – The Band and Makka Band. *Today from 4pm at YMCA, Nandanam. Free entry with registration. Expect an evening packed with Chennai flavours with local beats.*



Wine and dine

If you are a wine connoisseur, or want to learn about the world of wine join an intimate tasting experience at Tranquebar, ITC Grand Chola, with winemaker Namratha Stanley, as she takes us through the story of Solicantus wine, its terroir and the art of its making. Relocating from India to France, she embarked on a transformative path that led her into the world of viticulture and winemaking. *Today at ITC Grand Chola from 6pm onwards. To register call 9962169701.*



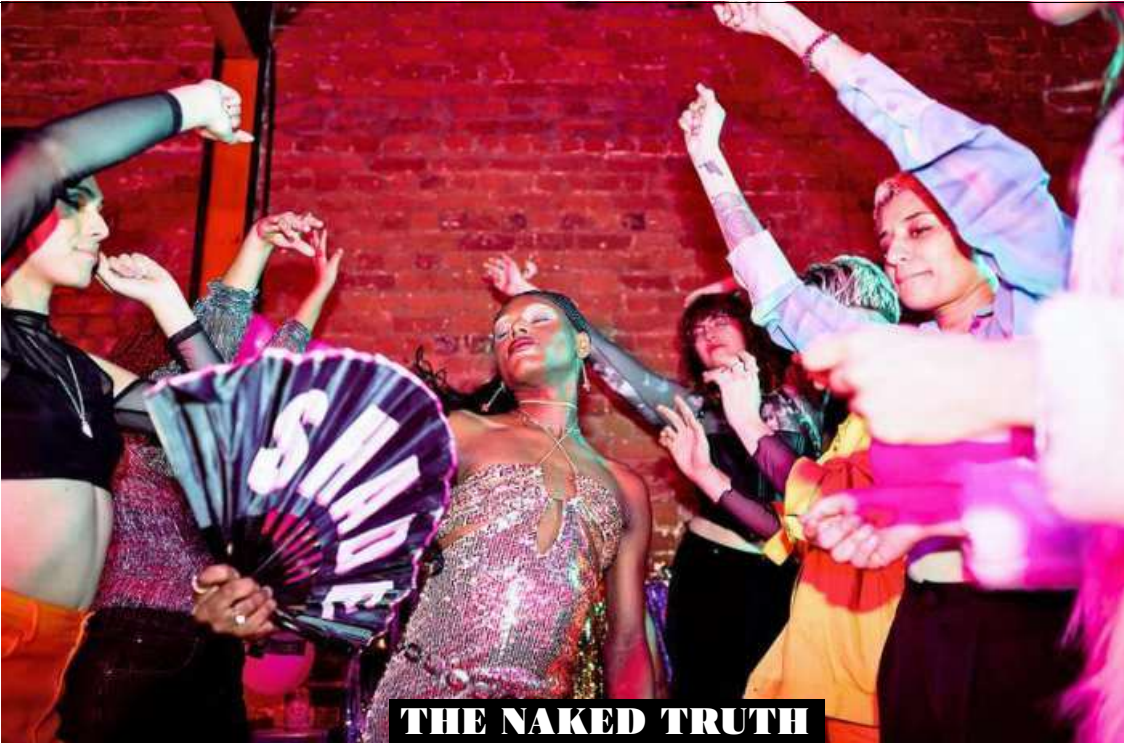
Nerd-out Sunday

This September, Pint of View Chennai turns three Sunday afternoons into a masterclass. On September 6, filmmaker Samarth Mahajan, a national awardee, shares stories from India's borderlands. On the 20th, architect Shreya Krishnan uncovers Chennai's hidden water landscape. And in a bonus session on the 27th, Suresh Srinivasan breaks down the red flags behind stocks and scams. *For details, visit @pintofview.chennai on Instagram.*



Vir Das in the city

Vir Das is bringing Sounds of India, taking audiences on an immersive audio-visual stand-up journey through the everyday sounds, quirks and nuances of the country. Blending humour with storytelling, the international Emmy-winning comedian explores familiar experiences through a vibrant symphony of sound. *On October 31 at 7.30pm at Sir Mutha Venkatasubba Rao Concert Hall. Tickets from ₹1,999 on Bookmyshow.com*



THE NAKED TRUTH

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In India in 2026, bisexuality is more visible than it has ever been. Dating apps have given people the vocabulary, popular culture has become more willing to acknowledge sexual fluidity, and younger Indians seem considerably less attached to the idea that attraction must behave itself inside one of two boxes. Tinder's 2023 India research, based on a survey of 1,000 young Indian daters aged 18-25, found that 33% said their sexual orientation was more fluid than it had been three years earlier, while 56% said they were open to dating people with diverse gender identities, sexual orientations and gender expressions. That does not mean 33% of young Indians are bisexual. Fluidity and bisexuality aren't interchangeable. But the number does suggest something has shifted: young people are becoming less convinced that attraction needs to come with a permanent Government-issued certificate. A friend of mine has identified as bisexual as long as I've known him. He isn't someone who "discovered" bisexuality after a particularly confusing

Bi the way

India is becoming more comfortable with sexual fluidity, but bisexual men and women are still navigating stigma, fetishisation and the strange demand to pick a side

Saturday night. He has always known. What he has discovered, repeatedly, is that other people find the concept considerably more confusing than he does. "With women, there's always this question of whether I'm actually bi," he tells me. "They want to know if I'm secretly gay, or if I'm eventually going to leave them for a man." With men, he says, the suspicion can go in the other direction. "Some gay men think you're just not ready to admit you're gay. And some men hear bisexual and think you're automatically sexually adventurous." **Soft spot** My friend in Bengaluru has had longer-term relationships with

women but says she has often felt more inclined to hook up with men while having deeper emotional relationships with women. Dating men, however, comes with its own peculiar hazards. "I'm always fetishised," she tells me. She has repeatedly been propositioned for threesomes. "I'm not open to that," she says. She says this hasn't changed much for her "in over a decade". A 2022 study, published in the *Journal of Homosexuality*, Gendered Anti-Bisexual Bias: Heterosexual, Bisexual, and Gay/Lesbian People's Willingness to Date Sexual Orientation Ingroup and Outgroup Members, surveyed 1,823 participants. Researchers found that heterosexual and gay/lesbian

people were less willing to date bisexual people than bisexual people were to date them. The reluctance was particularly strong towards bisexual men, and, notably, even bisexual women showed a preference against dating bisexual men. Then there is the 50-year-old woman in Kolkata who discovered bisexuality after her marriage dissolved in 2022. She has enjoyed the company of men and women, but rejects the idea that she woke up one morning and selected a new orientation from a dropdown menu. "It's not that you wake up choosing one gender over the other one fine day," she says. "It's a basic human connection." She says she can gravitate towards a man or a woman

depending on the person. "A lot of people think we wake up choosing to like a specific gender," she says. "I don't particularly like that." Her siblings know about her "newfound orientation". Friends can be another matter.

Not as simple There is an important difference between being able to say "I'm bisexual" and being able to find other bisexual people. Which means the offline infrastructure matters. And here, things become considerably more scrappy. Delhi has had Bi Collective Delhi, an independent voluntary collective for bisexual, bi-, bi-curious and pansexual people. Mumbai has Umang, the LBT support group of The Humsafar Trust, which includes bisexual women and trans people and has historically run workshops, and social events. But a dedicated, nationwide offline bisexual social infrastructure is hardly flourishing. It's safe to say that bisexual people are still negotiating a world where their sexuality can itself be a disadvantage in the dating market.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum



(Clockwise from left) Watercolours by Pradip Maitra; and sculptures by Bimal Kundu. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Echoes of Bengal

The legacy of Bengal's artistic traditions finds expression at Artworld Sarala's Art Centre, through an exhibition by artists Pradip Maitra and Bimal Kundu

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At Artworld Sarala's Art Centre, it feels like stepping back into the Bengal School of Art and its legacies, an early 20th-Century movement that sought to forge a distinct Indian artistic identity by reviving indigenous traditions and moving away from Western academic realism. The movement was shaped by prominent artists such as Abanindranath Tagore and Nandalal Bose, while figures such as Gaganendranath Tagore pushed its visual language towards a new form of modernism. Techniques such as wash and tempera became famous, drawing inspiration from the Japanese watercolour methods and the ancient frescoes of the Ajanta Caves. The same legacy can be seen in the works of artists such as Bimal Kundu and Pradip Maitra, both from Bengal, whose practices over the decades have remained rooted in this distinct visual language. Having been taught by some of the movement's pioneers, their works carry not only their own artistic sensibilities but also a strong



connection to the generations of artists who came before them. **Watercolour reveries** In Pradip Maitra's watercolours, he is inspired by the Victorian era, some of which reflects in his paintings. The painting, *She in the Costume*, features a lady wearing a red gown with patterns and frills that is reminiscent of the time when Calcutta was the capital under British rule. All of his watercolours are rendered

in transparent colour layers, where diluted layers of colours are applied multiple times to create the translucent effect on paper. "For my watercolours I am inspired by artists like JMW Turner and Shyamal Dutta Ray whose techniques I use in my paintings," says Maitra. In some of Maitra's watercolour paintings, locks become a recurrent theme,

which the artist attributes to the COVID pandemic and the subsequent lockdown, where people were confined to their homes. "It was the first time in my life that I saw the entire world locked out, and everything closed. I saw locks everywhere, from my door to my neighbour's, local shops, and across society," he says. "I also felt that if the world was to end today, and something has to remain, it should be my art," he adds.

Sculpting stories If Pradip Maitra chose brush and paper, Bimal Kundu chose sculpting as his artistic language. His portraits are known for being peaceful, serene, and meditative, which he says is an inspiration from the Bengal School of Art and his growing up in North Calcutta. His sculptures are also everyday observations; in one, a woman can be seen reclining, in an almost meditative state, a familiar sight in Bengali households on afternoons. "The sculpture captures a moment of leisure, when the women of the household, having finished their chores, would lie on the bed and let their hair loose, spreading it across the bed," says Kundu. Kundu describes his artistic journey as a homage to his time spent in Kumartuli, the artisan and potters' quarter in North Kolkata, famous for crafting Durga idols. "I have spent almost 10 years with the idol makers; I have learned everything from them, from sourcing the clay to rolling it out. It only helped me later as an artist to master my own craft," says Kundu. Music also plays an important role in his life, which is reflected in the sculptures; some of them can be seen with the veena and the sitar. "My musician series sculptures are inspired by legendary classical musicians such as Amjad Ali Khan, Ravi Shankar, Ali Akbar Khan, and Vilayat Khan," says Kundu. Together, the works of Pradip Maitra and Bimal Kundu offer a glimpse into how the legacy of the Bengal School continues to evolve through different mediums and generations.

The exhibition of paintings and sculptures is on at Artworld - Sarala's Art Centre, Ganeshpuram Street, Teynampet till September 10 (Monday to Saturday from 11am to 6pm). Entry is free, and open to all.

Seriously, what song?

Listen to The Dipshit Ladies turning everyday chaos, awkward moments and nonsense into funny songs



(From left) Nyma Singh Merchant, Neerja Ramnath and Radha Sunder. SHANTANU KRISHNAN

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A song about a sandwich, another about a washing machine, and even one about rabies and apologies – if that sounds nonsensical, that is precisely the point of this three-women band. Their comedy music finds humour in the everyday, exploring "things that you notice every day but do not talk about, but should be talking about," says Neerja Ramnath, one of the members of The Dipshit Ladies. Having known each other for many years, Radha Sunder says, they started music just for "fun", until a friend noticed them and suggested they do a show. They played their first skit at The Angular Festival, an art and music festival in Chennai on May 16 this year, which gave them enough confidence to perform their first solo show. "Women are so funny, but we don't get enough spaces to express that funny. But it's comforting to have each other to be funny with, and it feels a little less daunting to present that back to the world," says Radha. So what's with the name? "All three of us are a bit all over the place, so we often laugh at our general dipsh***y-ness. And while it started as a joke, it honestly just fit. The name also gives us the freedom to really be ourselves and not take things too seriously," chimes in Nyma Singh Merchant. "We are not trying to be perfect musicians; we are just trying to have a good time," says Neerja.

The Dipshit Ladies will be performing today at Kat and Kin Coffee Roasters, Sri Kapaleeswarar Nagar, Neelankarai, from 11am onwards. Tickets on bookmyshow.com



Nivedita Javaram Pawar

Every week, a new restaurant opens in Mumbai promising to be different. Most will not be around long enough to prove it. Industry estimates suggest that 70-80% of new restaurants in India shut within their first few years, according to Petpooja, a restaurant technology platform that tracks industry data. Rent alone can sink a business before it finds its footing. Add fickle diners, rising food costs and a city always chasing the next big thing, and most restaurants disappear before they become anyone's memory.

Yet a handful of Mumbai institutions have dodged that fate. Gulmurg, tucked inside The Shalimar Hotel at Kemp's Corner, has been serving North Indian cuisine since 1962. Gaylord in Churchgate, once frequented by Raj Kapoor and George Harrison, is still thriving nearly seven decades later. Gallops, which has been around since the 1980s, overlooking the Mahalaxmi Racecourse, remains the dining room of choice for generations of old Mumbai. Between them, they have survived recessions, the pandemic and the relentless churn of the city's dining scene.

So what keeps a restaurant alive once nostalgia alone isn't enough? The answer, it turns out, is not reinvention but refinement.

At Gulmurg, that responsibility now rests with third-generation owner Yash Advani, who recently oversaw an

18-month restoration. The revamp introduced a contemporary bar and an elevated cocktail programme, featuring drinks such as the Nimbupani Highball and a fat-washed Old Fashioned. But the heart of the restaurant remains unchanged.

"We are still a North Indian-focussed restaurant, not going the whole fusion route at all," says Yash.

Roughly half the menu still consists of the classics that built Gulmurg's reputation: paneer makhnwala, murg makhnwala, tikka masala and the biryanis regulars have been ordering for decades. The changes, however, are subtler — a chaat trolley, tapas-style small plates and more polished presentation.

He attributes the restaurant's longevity to business discipline and culinary instinct. Long-standing vendor relationships have helped cushion rising ingredient costs, while the family diversified beyond the dining room. During Gulmurg's renovation, they strengthened delivery, takeaway and outdoor catering operations instead of relying solely on dine-in



Never off menu

Family-run institutions like Gulmurg, Gaylord and Gallops, in Mumbai, reveal how consistency, loyal staff and thoughtful reinvention have helped them outlast changing food trends

business. A consulting chef was also brought in to develop contemporary additions without compromising the legacy menu. The detail Yash returns to most, however, is his staff. Several members have been with Gulmurg for nearly three decades.

"People are the most valuable thing in this industry. If our own people are happy, our guests will be looked after. And there's a comfort

in returning to staff who know your name and remember your order," he says.

Secret sauce
Gaylord tells a similar story. After decades under Sunil Lamba's stewardship, the restaurant is now run by his sons, Dhruv and Divij, who oversaw a 11-month renovation in 2024. The time-worn interiors gave way to crystal chandeliers, a faux skylight ceiling and softly lit

(Clockwise from far left) The dining room at Gallops; the food spread at Gaylord; the new bar at Gaylord; the daab chingri at Gallops; and the lotus stem chaat at Gulmurg. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



booths, while sepia photographs of Mumbai landmarks and famous regulars, including George Harrison and Sir Edmund Hillary, continue to line the walls. Live piano and saxophone performances now accompany dinner service.

The menu, meanwhile, added around 15 new dishes while retaining favourites such as chicken à la Kiev, prawn cocktail and the iconic Kwaliti chana bhatura.

Gallops has followed a similar playbook. In 2024, the Mahalaxmi institution underwent its own facelift carried out by the same architect who designed it 26 years ago, Vistasp Kharas of Vistasp Kharas Studio. The dining room now has arched glass windows that frame the racecourse and walls decked out with equestrian memorabilia including original racecourse

drawings from the private collection of architect Minocher Mistri. A new bar featuring a paper installation by Dutch artist Peter Gentenaar now anchors the room.

Around 40 new dishes have been included in the menu, while signatures such as chicken à la Kiev, chicken Cecilia, prawn thermidor and vegetable au gratin remain untouched. Newer additions, including the chicken liver pâté, chargrilled cauliflower with harissa tahini and daab chingri, sit alongside the classics. The cocktail programme, curated by partner Mikhail Singh, follows the same philosophy, pairing drinks with both the food and the restaurant's mood.

For chef and co-owner Yajush Malik, the second generation now running Gallops, balancing legacy with change is a daily exercise.

The restaurant's chicken in red wine pepper sauce is its highest food-cost dish. Economically, it makes little sense to keep, yet regulars continue to order it, so it stays.

Regional dishes from Kashmir, Bengal and Kerala, once considered too niche for mainstream diners, have become some of the restaurant's strongest performers.

"It essentially boils down to something very simple: quality. Food and service quality can't be erratic. When someone has an incredible meal, they're likely to come back. But if the second visit isn't as good as the first, you have a high chance of losing that customer," he says.

It is a lesson he believes many new restaurants overlook as they focus on opening-week buzz rather than the experience that follows.

In the early 2000s, Gallops nearly lost its signature galawat kebab when the Lucknow supplier behind its proprietary spice blend passed away. Rather than depending on a supplier, Yajush's father Rahul Malik painstakingly reverse-engineered the masala in-house.

"Our parents were very clear that we couldn't walk in as the new bosses. The habits and preferences of our regulars live with our staff, not in a manual. That's knowledge that has to be inherited," recalls Yajush.

In an industry obsessed with what's next, Mumbai's oldest restaurants have endured by perfecting what they already do well.

A new museum, special feasts, textile experiments and ambitious plans for its storied mansions will mark the fifth edition of the Chettinad Heritage and Cultural Festival

Past forward

Rahul Jacob

For V Ravichandar, a recent first visit to the fabled mansions of Chettinad was inspiring. Ravichandar, who guided the Bangalore International Centre through its formative years and is the founder of Bengaluru Hubba returned home fizzing with ideas. Impressed by the street layout of Chettinad towns that are akin to New York's grid and their mansions in a medley of architectural styles ranging from Art Deco to Art Nouveau, Ravichandar is determined to start a residency for architects and students in a restored mansion there.

He is attending the upcoming Chettinad Cultural Festival, which runs from September 18-22, and believes the festival has the

potential to make Chettinad a location for midsized conferences and something approaching an all-year destination, just as the Fringe Festival did for Edinburgh.

As the Chettinad Cultural and Heritage Festival turns five this year, its offerings are varied and traditional. Author and Member of Lok Sabha, Shashi Tharoor is scheduled to speak about the idea of India, while there are also talks that spotlight the architectural traditions of South India.

The Registry of Sarees is holding an exhibition which will see cultural impresario Malvika Singh, who has worked on cultural projects across Rajasthan as part of an advisory council to former Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje, speak about patronage and textiles.

To spotlight textiles and craft, Ashdeen Lilaowala is set to present



a choreographed show with Yali dancers. This promises to be a genre-defying show-stopper in dance form of the Registry's contemporary-classic take on textiles.

Ally Matthan, who founded the Registry of Sarees, says the exhibition and talk between Peter Lee and Lilaowala brings together Parsi, Peranakan and Chettiar cultures in a manner that refutes notions of "cultural appropriation" and focusses instead on a confluence of cultures.

The visitors this year include a contingent of about 10 from

(Clockwise from above) Art, architecture, history, textile traditions and more await visitors at Chettinad. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND SANGITA RAJAN

Singapore as well as visitors from the UK and France.

The opening of a new museum of Chettinad culture in part of the home of Crafts Council India chairperson Visalakshi Ramaswamy promises to be a must-see attraction this year and beyond. She believes museums are often crammed full of objects, but visitors often come away with scant understanding of how they were used.

House of memories
Visalakshi, who revived basket weaving and reinvigorated sari making traditions in Chettinad, and founded the acclaimed Chennai store Manjal, is also planning a library of documents and books on Chettinad in her room.

Chettinad lunches and dinners with dishes from Sri Lanka, Malaysia and Singapore are always part of the festival's generous offerings. Even so, this year's hawkler's dinner will feature dishes from Myanmar and dishes from across Southeast Asia.



Another dinner during the festival pays homage to the Chettiar trade with Sri Lanka.

The Bangala, and by extension the festival's lunches and dinners, is far removed from the over spiced and oily food Chettinad restaurants often serve. Some visitors may be overwhelmed by large breakfasts, banana leaf lunches with countless dishes and eclectic, cosmopolitan dinners but Meenakshi Meyyappan, 92, who founded the festival says, "People expect a feast when they come to Chettinad."

Festival passes and rooms remain on offer at Chidambara Vilas, the French-designed Saratha Vilas Chettinad Palace and Priya Paul's The Lotus Palace Chettinad by The Park Hotels.

As it goes forward, the festival will need to cast its net wider and address more global and national themes as well as engage with younger audiences on social media. The effort to draw future travellers to still relatively under-visited towns populated by what *The New York Times* memorably called India's definitive "party mansions" continues. The show must go on.

For details, write to chettinadheritagefestival@gmail.com.





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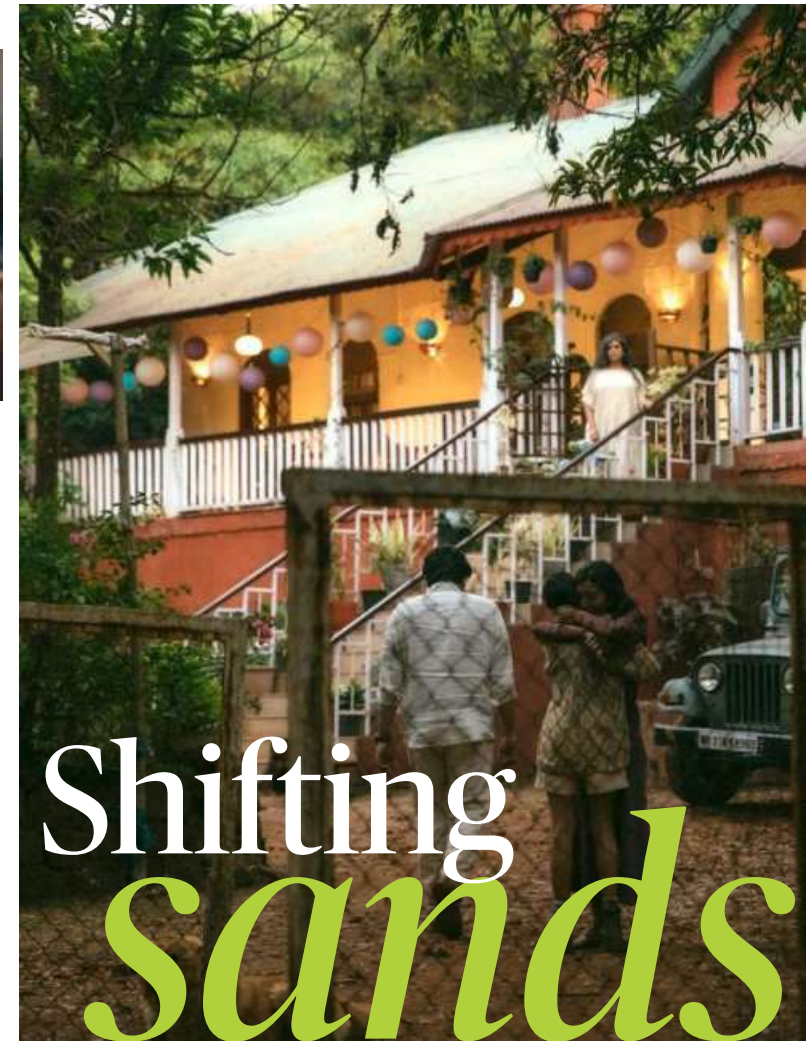
Chilean-Indian filmmaker Shalini Adnani's *Our Share of Sand* enters the 41st Venice International Critics' Week as one of seven debut features competing in the section. The film, which has its world premiere on September 4, follows 12-year-old Maya as she returns to rural India with her mother and reconnects with her estranged father, a sand-mining businessman whose operation employs young workers in hazardous conditions. An accident involving Maya's friend and family help, Kiran, turns her into a witness to the family's carefully maintained version of events.

Crossing cultures

Born in Chile to a Sindhi-Indian family and now based in London, Shalini grew up moving between two cultures that gave her very different but equally intimate ideas of home. Her family's roots brought her repeatedly to India, where she divided her time between Ahmedabad, Mumbai and Chennai, while Chile remained the other place that shaped her sense of belonging. "I think I couldn't separate those two identities for me as a person," she says in a virtual interview with *The Hindu*. "I did grow up between two cultures that I

actually love. I love Latin American culture and I love Indian culture. I almost feel like I'm pulled to pick one in a society or in a world that is constantly asking us to be binary and pick one or the other," she says. That tension between belonging and observation is also built into Maya, played by newcomer Maya Mehta, whose place within the family gives her an intimate view of its privilege while her position as an outsider to the world around it leaves her unusually alert to what the adults have learned to accept. "The heart of *Our Share of Sand* came from my experiences going to India and spending time as a sort of NRI in the house," Shalini says. "Understanding a country through the microcosm of a family," was the thought behind Maya becoming close enough to inherit the family's assumptions and young enough to still find their consequences difficult to absorb.

That family bubble also shaped what Shalini noticed outside it. In *Our Share of Sand*, Maya's father is an industrialist whose cement business depends on the manual extraction of river sand, with workers diving into the riverbed to collect it by hand, exposing them to the physical dangers of barotrauma. When Maya joins one of her father's nighttime mining trips, 14-year-old Kiran is sent underwater and fails to resurface, eventually emerging with ruptured eardrums and permanent hearing damage. The accident becomes the point at



Ahead of *Our Share of Sand*'s Venice Critics' Week premiere, Chilean-Indian filmmaker Shalini Adnani on India's development boom and its human cost

which Maya begins to question the version of her family's world that she has inherited. "I ended up having a very strong understanding of how India was progressing through what it was building. I think my understanding of India really came through the excavation of these raw materials, turning into this... Western dream, or development," she says. **At its heart** The film's premise draws from a real labour system. According to Maharashtra Government project

(Clockwise from left) Stills from the film; and filmmaker Shalini Adnani. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

documentation, manual sand mining involves workers digging and loading river sand by hand, a system that places much of the physical burden of extraction on labourers. The Union Environment Ministry's latest available response on illegal sand mining, issued in August 2024, lists riverbed degradation, loss of aquatic habitat, groundwater depletion, soil erosion and flooding among its environmental consequences, while stating that legal extraction is governed by limits on the volume and depth of mining. Shalini's understanding of that labour was shaped by her experience of growing up in Chile. "Chile is a country of extraction as well. It's a mining country," she says. She connects the extraction of natural resources to a broader hierarchy around labour.

Moral greys The film's embedded class politics also surface in the ease and banality with which its privileged characters talk about workers, displacement and development. Maya occupies an uncomfortable position within this system, with enough privilege to observe it and enough distance to question what her family has normalised. "The outsider is in a privileged position to be

able to observe something, but it's also a kind of entitled position to say, this is right or this is wrong," Shalini says. These concerns with morality stretch back through Shalini's earlier work. Her Sundance-premiering short *White Ant* centred on a man returning to his ancestral Indian home as termites consume the property, while *Somebody's Daughter* followed a young girl whose understanding of her father changes after she accompanies him to a humiliating job interview. "I was particularly interested in exploring the grey areas of morality and what's right and wrong," she says. The production itself required Shalini to rethink the film's relationship with its landscape. The 37-day shoot eventually took the crew to Mahabaleshwar and Jambhali, a tiny village without Wi-Fi or mobile reception, where the practical isolation became part of the filmmaking process. Venice marks another major step for Shalini, who was named a Screen International Star of Tomorrow in 2025. Her next projects will take her beyond India. "I have a particular book that I want to adapt. I'm slowly spending so much time in India that I know that there are other stories I want to tell there," she says.



Dil Chahta Hai now in your wardrobe

Twenty-five years after *Dil Chahta Hai* made friendship, road trips and Chapora Fort part of pop culture, H&M is bringing the film's unmistakable style to a new generation. Created in collaboration with Excel Entertainment, the exclusive capsule collection turns some of the movie's most memorable imagery into wearable nostalgia. Expect graphic T-shirts across the men's and women's collections, featuring bold designs in black, off-white and red, with references to the iconic Chapora Fort and the film's effortlessly cool aesthetic. Whether you are an Akash, Sameer or Sid, there is a little something here to channel your favourite DCH-era mood. The collection, launched on August 27, is available at select H&M stores across India and online at hm.com. Prices start at ₹1,499.

Cliff Booth returns

Brad Pitt is set to reprise his role as stuntman Cliff Booth in *The Further Mis-Adventures of Cliff Booth*, a new feature written by Quentin Tarantino and directed by David Fincher. The film serves as a follow-up to Tarantino's 2019 film *Once Upon a Time in Hollywood*, which won Pitt an Oscar for Best Supporting Actor. Set in 1977, the story follows Cliff eight years after the events of the original film, taking him into another chapter of Hollywood's changing landscape. While Tarantino has written the screenplay, Fincher will direct, marking a notable collaboration between two filmmakers with distinctly different cinematic styles. Pitt will be joined by Elizabeth Debicki, Scott Caan, Carla Gugino, Yahya Abdul-Mateen II and Peter Weller. The film is scheduled for an IMAX release on November 25, followed by its Netflix premiere on December 23. The project also reunites Pitt with a character that became one of his most memorable recent roles.



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Girish AD works his magic yet again



SR Praveen
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Of all the things Justin (Nivin Pauly) and Ashley (Mamitha Baiju), the protagonists of *Bethlehem Kudumba Unit*, bond over, music is perhaps what triggers the initial spark. She is surprised that he has heard of the alternative rock band ‘Breeders’, her favourite. It changes her serious, old-man image of him.

When Ashley lands in this neighbourhood with her family, reluctant to leave her small home in the village, she is a little circumspect and even melancholic. Soon, she gels in, as if she has found her tribe. Girish AD does something similar with the audience. He places us firmly amid this bunch of closely-knit characters, all with relatable qualities, quirks and failings, making us feel as if we are among a group of our own friends. It also feels as if everyone here, except Ashley and her family have known each other all their lives, for such is the easy camaraderie and the sharpness of the repartees.

His organic flow is visible in the many relatable situations too, which hardly seem scripted. Be it Roshan Shanavas, Suresh Krishna, Shameer, Sangeeth Prathap, Shyam Mohan, or Bindu Panicker or any of the others who play smaller characters, almost everyone has something which leaves a mark. For that matter, humour is peppered throughout the film, even in the seemingly grim or emotional scenarios in the climax. The many cheeky references to contemporary films are also seamlessly woven in. Vishnu Vijay’s music gets the feel of the movie.

The depiction of the age-gap relationship between Justin and Ashley could have easily gone wrong, if not for the delicate handling by the writers, ably supported by the actors. Not for a moment does it fall into an awkward space. The whole movie feels like a gentle persuasion to make us believe this relationship isn’t wrong, as society believes. Nivin and Mamitha share a sparkling chemistry, melting our thoughts about the age gap.

Mamitha’s character is totally unlike Reenu in Girish AD’s *Premalu* or any of her other recent roles, and it is a credit to the actor’s adaptability that she could easily bring a fresh spin to most of these roles. After finding form last in *Sarvam Maya*, Nivin Pauly yet again works up his natural charm to full effect.

Girish AD is one of the most interesting filmmakers in Malayalam cinema, especially for the endless supply of relatable, humorous situations that propel his films, where the stories are not out of the ordinary. *Bethlehem Kudumba Unit* certainly ranks among his best, alongside *Premalu* and *Thanneer Mathan Dinangal*.

Bethlehem Kudumba Unit is currently running in theatres



A juvenile take on gender roles

Actor-director Elan’s Netflix rom-com wants to challenge traditional gender roles, but repeatedly falls back on the stereotypes it seeks to question

Tamil

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Imagine what your home means to you. How you grew roots, bloomed into an adult, surrounded by bonds you have worked continuously on, in a safe environment that understands you in all your states. Now imagine abandoning it all one fine day. This reality takes a darker turn for the majority of women in our society. After their wedding, they must not only move away from their family and home, but also lose their identity and dreams and become a “dutiful daughter-in-law” and a “homely wife.”

This normalised ill-fated reality is the subject of the latest Tamil rom-com, *Pyaar Prema Kalyanam*, directed by Elan and currently streaming on Netflix. In his third feature film as a director, Elan attempts a pulpy, accessible, and entertaining message film. Unfortunately, the filmmaker seems ill-equipped to handle that style of cinema.

After the cheery wedding festivities of Elan (played by the actor-director) and Pavithra (Saanve Megghana), the newlywed bride is expected to hop into the car and be taken away to her in-laws’ house. But something clicks in Pavi’s head. She jumps out of the car and dashes out of the venue, as her helpless new husband runs after her in utter confusion. This is the very scene with which *PPK* kicks off, and over the next two hours, we see how the pair met and fell in love, why Pavi chose not to move to Elan’s house, and, as revealed by the trailer, what happens when Elan chooses to flip the switch and becomes a househusband at Pavi’s.

Everything about this snappy one-liner makes you sit right up. Even the way we are introduced to the flashbacks of Elan and Pavi speaks so much about who they are and who they end up as. Pavi approaches her responsibilities as the working adult of the family with utmost love and pride. Meanwhile, we meet Elan, a bored civil engineer in Dubai, who willingly jeopardises his job to return home and eat his mother’s crispy dosas;

Pyaar Prema Kalyanam

Director: Elan

Cast: Elan, Saanve Megghana, Radikaa Sarathkumar, Elango Kumaravel

Storyline: A newlywed couple’s life takes an unexpected turn when the bride chooses to stay at her home, leaving her husband to embrace the role of a househusband



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home means a lot to Elan as well, but unlike Pavi, this man reeks of incompetence.

Much of the first 30-40 minutes of the film goes so smoothly as you see a rather unusual meet-cute transpire between the lead pair. They then get married, and we know what happens. Now, in another film, one might wonder how a couple in love wouldn’t have discussed something as basic as how they would lead their lives post-marriage. However, the fact that they never quite got to that part tells you how ingrained it is in Elan that he assumes his beloved would readily take up the automated life that awaits her.

PPK turns dull quickly enough. Once Elan enters Pavi’s house, the film attempts heavy-handed humour by exaggerating the notion that a man’s respect will be intact only if he has a job. We see how Pavi’s mother (Radikaa Sarathkumar) treats Elan with utmost reverence when his employment prospects are strong, and quickly mistreats him when he loses a job. On the surface, this might seem like a harmless jab, but this makes you wonder what stance the rest of the film is about to take – after all, you wouldn’t see any humour in a woman treating her daughter-in-law as such.

Many of these portions rightfully critique men’s incompetence. Still, the way the scenes are written does a great disservice to housewives and househusbands by treating the gender subversion like a party trick. In another instance, Pavi, who otherwise espouses feminist ideals, starts shaming her husband for wearing shorts in his house in the presence of a neighbouring woman. Again, this isn’t a serious dramatic moment that reveals Pavi’s shortfalls, but part of a long and abysmal track between Elan and Pavi’s mother, who wage wars like a stereotypical Tamil cinema mother-in-law and daughter-in-law. Also, how does a man who earned a living in Dubai all alone for 1.5 years not know that the money allocated from his wife’s monthly income for household expenditure is for the *whole* month?

For a big stretch – when Yuvan Shankar Raja’s superb ‘Love Is Beautiful’ track (sung by GV Prakash Kumar) plays – it seems the film might redeem these issues.

This is before Elan’s mother, upon seeing her son at his in-laws washing vessels, visualises him in a woman’s attire. It’s a crass idea that reinforces that a simple act of washing vessels is a woman’s job and questions the masculinity of competent, secure household men. Of course, you might argue that the film eventually speaks to how unfairly the world treats househusbands, but by then, Elan becomes the butt of the joke – and the message sent to men is that this might be their reality should they try their hand at roles traditionally assigned to women.

In the two-hour film, only a handful of scenes click. Early on, the famous television interview from Shankar’s *Mudhalvan* becomes a motif mirroring a television interview Pavi participates in. The idea sounds inventive, but the scene-writing doesn’t live up to its potential, which shows when the late legendary Raghuvaran’s dialogue – “You be the CM for one day and see for yourself” – plays at an apt moment.

In his acting debut, Elan looks and plays the part ably, but it is Saanve who stands out with her anchored performance as a woman who stands up for herself and her desire to lead her life on her terms. Yogi Babu plays a character equivalent to Karunaas’ in the *Gatta Kusthi* films, a typical male chauvinist who demands his wife be subservient; neither does Yogi bring in any memorable humour, nor does his arc feel organically written.

Seemingly written for the reel-viewing generation, *PPK* ends up as a glossy film whose good intentions rarely make a mark. It becomes even more apparent in the safe route it takes to resolve the conflict.

In an early scene, when a character wonders if there are caste differences between Pavi and Elan, someone replies, “Love is their caste.” If this reads like a sweet sentiment to you, perhaps *PPK* could become a harmless streaming watch. If you are someone who understands the sentiment behind that dialogue but shudders at the thought of love being equated to something like ‘caste,’ there might be other offerings for you .

Pyaar Prema Kalyanam is currently streaming on Netflix

Shiva Nirvana and Ravi Teja deliver an emotionally steeped tale

Telugu

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At the first sign of abuse, a character in the Telugu film *Irumudi* asks his daughter not to blow it up into a big issue. Another character empowers his daughter to be transparent and share all the happenings at school and the village without fear. These contrasting approaches of two fathers become the film’s biggest takeaway.

Shiva Nirvana begins to unravel the film with a sense of foreboding and maintains this mood until the very end. He sets the story in a village in Andhra Pradesh where bus connectivity is a luxury. Parents think twice before sending their children to a high school in a nearby town. The film opens with an incident of corporal punishment meted out to an adolescent girl. This is contrasted by how the male protagonist, Trinath (Ravi Teja),



beats up a truck driver for honking loudly at the crack of dawn when his daughter is still asleep.

It is a given that these two worlds will collide. As several characters in the village are introduced, the director, who has also written the film, drops ample hints at the danger that lurks all around.

What might have been a regular story of father-daughter bonding, threat and retaliation gets an additional layer of intrigue with the devotional fervour. Trinath is a

small-time trader who takes to the bottle barring the 41-day Ayyappa deeksha, much to the annoyance of his wife Kaveri (Priya Bhavani Shankar). The spiritual fervour is also used to establish the bond between Trinath and his daughter Manemma or Manikanta (child actor Nakshatra).

Trinath reiterates that he considers every girl child in the village to be his own daughter and hence will stand up for them. Subtle humour works as an undercurrent in the portions where Ravi Teja’s action

hero image is channelled into establishing him as a protective guardian for the girls in the village. His approach is starkly different from that of his family friend Guru ‘swamy’ (Sai Kumar).

At regular intervals, the narrative introduces ominous miscreants. Mercifully, Shiva Nirvana sidesteps some predictable tropes as the story progresses. There is danger, there is sexual assault, but thankfully the portrayal is not voyeuristic. And the perpetrators are not the usual suspects. They never are.

The ramifications of abuse can still shake up viewers because of the emotionally resonant storytelling. It exposes the vulnerability of a girl child and her parents. There is heartbreak, guilt, anger and rage.

This is the most sincere performance from Ravi Teja in the last few years. He is mostly restrained. Even in the action sequences, he does not get to unleash one-liners or any quirks associated with mass action templates. Nakshatra’s part has been written carefully, without going overboard, and the child actor comes

up with an innocent and effective portrayal. She is the soul of the film. The other adolescent students are also convincing in their parts.

Priya Bhavani Shankar might play the third character in the family drama dominated by the father and daughter, but she manages to make her presence felt with a sincere turn. We could see more of her in Telugu cinema. Sai Kumar, as always, chips in with a nuanced performance.

GV Prakash Kumar’s music adds

credence to the Ayyappa deeksha portions and conveys the sense of danger as the mystery deepens. Considerable support also comes from the technical team, including cinematographer Vishnu Sharma, production designer Sahi Suresh and costume designer Rajesh Kamarsu who do what is required for the story.

A major sore thumb in the narrative is the absence of law enforcement authorities. A mysterious death here and a purported murder elsewhere, but the police are nowhere to be seen. The single-note characterisation of the sinister teacher is another drawback.

One can debate on whether the pre-climax portions rely on shock value to make an emotional connect, but the storytelling remains effective that it is hard to look away from what’s unfolding.

Despite occasional missteps, *Irumudi* emerges as an emotionally moving drama.

Irumudi is currently playing in theatres.

Mutiny

Director:
Jean-François Richet

Cast: Jason Statham,
Annabelle Wallis,
Roland Møller, Adrian
Lester

Storyline: A man is
falsely accused of a
crime and goes
aboard a cargo ship to
uncover a conspiracy



Jason Statham deserved better

English

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Mutiny apparently began its life as a sequel to the 2023 Gerard Butler film, *Plane*, also directed by Jean-François Richet. It was to be called *Ship*, laying the path for sequels that could have been called *Train*, *Tank*, *Bus*, *Auto* and various other means of transport. When Butler decided against the sequel, the script was re-jigged to become this strange mess.

Cole Reed (Jason Statham) is one of those strong, silent men with a checkered past, including service as a Marine and a police officer with the Met in the UK. Now, he is the bodyguard to Thai shipping magnate Tibu Campalo (Ramon Tikaram) after saving his life five years ago.

Cole and Tibu are good friends, playing chess while discussing life and sundry stuff. Incidentally, when chess is introduced into a film, does a chess expert plot the moves? Tibu has decided to sell his company; as he tells Cole, the shipping empire was his dream, not his son Kameron's (Chaneil Kular). We see another businessman, Jaran (Simon Kluth), making sinister phone calls about stopping the deal.

On the way back from celebrating closing the deal, the car Tibu and Cole are in is attacked, and Tibu is killed. Cole is blamed for his boss's death and goes

on the run. For some reason, he gets on a cargo ship as a means of clearing his name. All who have been faithfully following the plot, such as it is, are left scratching their heads at the bizarre cause and effect.

A villainous captain, Marko Madsen (Roland Møller), a courageous third shipmate, Angie Ellis (Annabelle Wallis), who is dragged back to duty even though she promised her daughter she would be back in Los Angeles in two days, human trafficking rings and a very conscientious crew aboard a US destroyer are all running helter-skelter, while shady businessmen make calls and the captain squints dangerously as he shaves.

Jason Statham films are meant to be comfort watches where you know exactly what to expect – skull-cracking fights, wall-to-wall action and some wry one-liners packed into 90 minutes of

blindingly obvious fun. *Mutiny* commits the cardinal sin of moving at the pace of drying cement. The fights, when they remember to put them in, are treacle-paced, and by the time the hook comes into the frame, you are rolling your eyes muttering enough already.

The stunts are not imaginative, and the setting is not particularly claustrophobic. Places where there is a chance for some cool action sequences, such as Cole climbing down the gigantic anchor chain, inexplicably happen off-screen.

Mutiny, with its ludicrous plot – yes, action movies can get by on the seat of their pants, but then they should be propulsive rather than creeping along like a distraught tortoise – and unconvincing acting, is a disappointment on all fronts.

Mutiny is currently running in theatres

Snippets



Kit Harington to play Gilderoy Lockhart in HBO's Harry Potter

Kit Harington will play Gilderoy Lockhart in the second season of HBO's *Harry Potter* adaptation, with the network confirming that the actor has replaced Nicholas Hoult as the celebrity wizard and Hogwarts professor. The change was announced just days after Hoult was revealed as the new Defence Against the Dark Arts professor.

Lockhart is introduced in *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets*, which will form the basis of Season 2. Kenneth Branagh previously played the character in the 2002 film adaptation.

The first season, which adapts *Harry Potter and the Philosopher's Stone*, began production in 2025 and is scheduled to premiere on December 25, 2026.



Ajay Devgn's Drishyam 3 titled Drishyam The Conclusion

The third part in Ajay Devgn's *Drishyam* franchise has been titled *Drishyam The Conclusion*, the makers announced on Monday (August 24, 2026). Written by Abhishek Pathak, Aamil Keeyan Khan and Parveez Shaikh, the film has been directed by Abhishek Pathak.

The makers unveiled a new poster featuring Ajay to make the announcement. *Drishyam The Conclusion* also stars Tabu, Rajat Kapoor and Shriya Saran in pivotal roles.

Released in 2015, *Drishyam*, a remake of the Mohanlal starrer Malayalam film, told the story of an ordinary man, Vijay Salgaonkar, who gets embroiled in a murder investigation along with his family.



Kaaka: Chiranjeevi's next with Bobby Kolli gets a title

Telugu superstar Chiranjeevi's next with director Bobby Kolli has been titled *Kaaka*. The movie is bankrolled by KVN Productions, the banner behind *Toxic: A Fairy Tale for Grown-Ups* starring Yash and Vijay's *Jana Nayagan*.

On Chiranjeevi's 71st birthday, the makers released a title glimpse. Director Bobby Kolli reunites with Chiranjeevi after their hit 2023 movie *Waltair Veerayya*.

In the glimpse, Chiranjeevi is seen playing an ordinary working-class man, leading a quiet life. Essaying a character called Supervisor Satyam, working at Ammajji Aqua Industries, the actor is surrounded by prawns, fish, and the everyday bustle of the aquaculture business.



Further from its best

A handful of terrific set pieces suggest the *Insidious* imagination hasn't completely flatlined, though 'Out of the Further' still keeps reaching for the defibrillator

English

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The *Insidious* franchise began in 2010 as a scrappy collision between James Wan's love for old-school supernatural horror and Leigh Whannell's taste for grubby genre silliness. Sixteen years since, *Insidious: Out of the Further* now features another new demon and a fresh opportunity to make the Further feel dangerous again. Jacob Chase, who previously directed *Come Play*, writes and directs this sixth film, which shifts attention away from the Lambert family toward Gemma (Amelia Eve), a single mother living with her daughter Maya (Island Austin) in the house where Gemma's own mother died.

For the unattuned, Wan and Whannell built the series around a spirit world called the Further, where dead souls and demons hang around waiting to ruin someone's day. After five films, the early Lambert family's story has mostly run its course, so *Out of the Further* starts fresh with Gemma. The film opens in the past, when a young Gemma watches her demented mother kill herself. We then jump to the present, where Gemma is raising her daughter Maya in the same house. The trouble, naturally, has followed her home.

Despite the Blumhouse-Atomic Monster pedigree, you probably shouldn't be walking into the sixth *Insidious* expecting something as finely calibrated as *Obsession* or *Backrooms*. Unsurprisingly, plot and personality in this latest franchise outing has been granted the minimum operating budget required to get us from one scare to the next. Much of the film is drenched in that familiar silver-blue grading and persistent 'Further Fog', flattening every frame with the same refrigerated gloom. It also keeps piling on indicators that something

Insidious: Out of the Further

Director: Jacob Chase

Cast: Amelia Eve, Brandon Perea and Maisie Richardson-Sellers, Lin Shaye, Sam Spruell, Joseph Bishara

Storyline: Gemma is a young mother who discovers she can travel into the Further, a purgatorial realm of lost souls

terrible is happening, leaving the imagery with very little mystery to do any work.

Out of the Further does occasionally strike gold with some ingenious set pieces, especially when Gemma crawls into Maya's pillow fort and discovers that the thing has somehow become much bigger on the inside. The cushions open into a long, beige maze that turns the cosy hideout into a surprisingly nasty little nightmare. There's a *Backrooms* flavour to these endless upholstered passages and the sequence feels inspired by that one terrifying wall cavity sequence in Damian McCarthy's *Caveat*, though the gag remains quintessentially *Insidious*. Chase understands the claustrophobic value of spatial disorientation here, but it's a combination the rest of the film simply cannot manufacture.

Gemma's dental-hygienist setup also gives the film an unfortunate abundance of nausea-inducing material to work with, and so an assortment of gnarly teeth and repulsive oral sludge keep recurring periodically with almost vindictive enthusiasm. I've watched horror characters get butchered in ways that would make a butcher look away, but show me one properly rotten mouth and its game over for me. Dismemberment is fine, but gingivitis is where I draw the line.

In true *Insidious* fashion, there are plenty of other cheap-but-potent jump scares, though their steadily increasing frequency started to feel like the film defibrillating me every few minutes to make sure I hadn't nodded off.

The new villain could have also been fun. Cyrus Lam (Sam Spruell), a caricatured dead cult leader with an extravagant silhouette somewhere between Ozzy Osbourne and Marilyn Manson, commands a ghoulish following while plotting to bring the Further into our world. But the convoluted mythology is where the screenplay becomes particularly cumbersome.

Gemma's inherited psychic ability allows her to enter the Further and transport entities between dimensions, while Elise Rainier (Lin Shaye) continues

her posthumous career as the franchise's spectral problem-solver. The film keeps stopping to explain how all of this works, who can cross which boundary and why the latest threat requires Gemma specifically. Horror can survive almost any amount of supernatural nonsense when the images possess conviction, but here, the endless barrage of exposition sacrifices all the built up tension without actually supplying much usable logic in return.

The comically bad final act is where the film finally throws whatever restraint it had left into the Further. Having spent the entire runtime building toward the emancipation of Cyrus and his merry band of dead weirdos, the film suddenly remembers the *Insidious* back catalogue exists and stages an *Endgame*-style reunion of its greatest hits. A flurry of familiar ghouls, including, The Bride in Black turn up, followed by the shotgun-totting Doll Girl, the instantly-forgettable KeyFace, and finally bargain-bin Darth Maul, AKA good 'ol Lipstick-Face eventually gets dragged out for his contractual jump scare.

For all the nonsense it drags behind it, *Out of the Further* still retains the peculiar charm of that decade of 2010's horror, when most studios had little objection to the spooky lore becoming progressively more ridiculous, as long as the monsters remained memorable and the audience kept showing up. Its occasional bursts of goofy invention recall that period fondly, even when the film itself struggles to sustain the same energy. And it also appears designed as a contained chapter, tying this arc into a surprisingly neat conclusion.

That tidy ending may irritate anyone who likes their horror to leave a little poison in the bloodstream, but I found it quite refreshing. After six films, *Insidious* has squeezed an impressive amount of mileage out of the same red door and might finally consider leaving something behind for the next franchise.

Insidious: Out of the Further is currently running in theatres